

WHEN THE TABLES TURN

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: 2 Samuel 9:1-13 (NKJV) *“David said, “Is there still anyone who is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan’s sake?”² And there was a servant of the house of Saul whose name was Ziba (Zee-baw). So when they had called him to David, the king said to him, “Are you Ziba (Zee-baw)?” He said, “At your service!”³ Then the king said, “Is there not still someone of the house of Saul, to whom I may show the kindness of God?” And Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, “There is still a son of Jonathan who is lame in his feet.”⁴ So the king said to him, “Where is he?” And Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, “Indeed he is in the house of Machir (May-kur) the son of Ammiel (Aim-ee-el), in Lo Debar (Low-dee-bar).”⁵ Then King David sent and brought him out of the house of Machir (May-kur) the son of Ammiel (Aim-ee-el), from Lo Debar (Low-dee-bar).⁶ Now when Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, had come to David, he fell on his face and prostrated himself. Then David said, “Mephibosheth?” And he answered, “Here is your servant!”⁷ So David said to him, “Do not fear, for I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father’s sake, and will restore to you all the land of Saul your grandfather; and you shall eat bread at my table continually.”⁸ Then he bowed himself, and said, “What is your servant, that you should look upon such a dead dog as I?”⁹ And the*

king called to Ziba (Zee-baw), Saul's servant, and said to him, "I have given to your master's son all that belonged to Saul and to all his house."¹⁰ You therefore, and your sons and your servants, shall work the land for him, and you shall bring in the harvest, that your master's son may have food to eat. But Mephibosheth your master's son shall eat bread at my table always." Now Ziba (Zee-baw) had fifteen sons and twenty servants.¹¹ Then Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, "According to all that my lord the king has commanded his servant, so will your servant do." "As for Mephibosheth," said the king, "he shall eat at my table like one of the king's sons."¹² Mephibosheth had a young son whose name was Micha. And all who dwelt in the house of Ziba (Zee-baw) were servants of Mephibosheth.¹³ So Mephibosheth dwelt in Jerusalem, for he ate continually at the king's table. And he was lame in both his feet."

INTRO: The definition of "*Turning the Tables*" is to reverse the position of adversaries so that the weaker position becomes the dominant position. Examples of turning the tables would be:

- Football... (Reverse the field after each quarter)
- Basketball... (Reverse the court after each period)

The setting for this wonderful story of honor, grace and reconciliation has its foundation in a

friendship between Jonathan, the son of Saul, and David, a shepherd transitioning to King!

When Saul the first King of Israel, sinned against the Lord, the prophet came to the house of Jesse and anointed David to be the successor of Saul.

Through a violent battle with his archenemy, the Philistines, Saul was deposed as King and he and his sons were killed in that very battle. Remember, ***“Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall.”***

As a matter of course, when a King was deposed in the manner that Saul was, his entire family line was to either be killed or exiled. In addition, all of their wealth was to become the property of their successor or of the nation itself.

When Saul was defeated, David began to rule over Judah and reigned for seven years and six months, at which time he began presiding over the entire nation and moved his governmental headquarters to Jerusalem. In the process of time David decided to find out whether there were any descendants of the house of Saul who remained.

I. EVERYTHING IS NOT AS IT SEEMS...

David asked one of Saul's unemployed servants of the whereabouts of the descendants of Saul.

Ziba revealed there was one lone descendent of Saul, who happened to be the son of Jonathan but had been handicapped by a fall. Ziba revealed this descendant was living in the House of Machir in Lo Debar.

Mephibosheth, once a prince was doing life as a pauper! When Mephibosheth was five years old, his grandfather Saul and his father Jonathan were killed in a battle against the Philistines.

When the nanny who was caring for Mephibosheth heard of the tragic results of the battle between the Israelites and Philistines she picked up five-year-old Mephibosheth, and made a run-for-it. In her haste to flee she dropped the child and he suffered a spinal injury. **In one tragic day**, at the age of five **Mephibosheth: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Lost his mobility...
- Lost his position as a prince...
- Lost a very influential grandfather...
- Lost a father who no doubt adored him...
- Lost his ability to make a living because of his injury...
- Lost the security of being protected as a result of his family name...

Remember, everything is not as it seems! Not only did Mephibosheth lose all of these things, Ziba revealed that he was living in the house of Machir, in Lo Debar. Interestingly enough, Machir is the brother of Bathsheba!

Machir, the son of Ammiel resided in Lo Debar. The name Ammiel comes from the Hebrew word “*ammiyel*,” meaning, “*People of God.*” The word Machir comes from the Hebrew word, “*makik*” (maw-kak) meaning “*To be brought low – decaying.*” The place Lo Debar was a pasture-less place in Palestine, probably desert and therefore more than likely it was a poverty stricken place.

Notice the sad trajectory of this once promising family with whom Mephibosheth was living:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- At one time they were the people of God...
- They had been brought low...
- They were living in a poverty stricken place...

If that is not bad enough, Mephibosheth was living with them, and had become completely reliant on their mercy and resources! If they were in a dreadful spot in their lives, Mephibosheth was in an even worse position!

Remember, everything is not as it seems! God is able to turn the tables on the enemy!

This is where the story begins to turn! In this passage of scripture, Ziba is a type of the Holy Spirit: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- David did not know if Saul had any surviving family members, but Ziba did...

- David did not know about Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...
- David did not know where to find Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...
- David did not know about the condition of Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...

Others may not know you are alive and in the condition you are in, but God the Holy Spirit does! If we will allow the Holy Spirit to get involved in our devastating situation, He WILL turn the tables on the devil! Everything is not what it seems!

II. MOST THINGS ARE BETTER THAN THEY SEEM...

The pattern for Mephibosheth seemed to be:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- One failure after another...
- Frustrations that built one upon another...
- Dashed dreams that appeared to be forever gone...
- Disillusionments that appeared impossible to resolve...
- Disappointments that remained unsettled year after year...

Mephibosheth started life as a Prince who would very likely sit on the throne of his grandfather Saul. He found himself rendered immobile by a fall, unable to make a living, totally dependent on the generosity of financially destitute extended family members!

There were no indicators that the forecast for his life was about to take a dramatic turn for the better. **Mephibosheth assumed his life would be permanently pitiful.** Most things are better than they seem!

Our lives were a pathetic disgrace until the Father sent the Holy Spirit to knock on the door to our hearts. When we opened the door to the Holy Spirit, He revealed the fathers intentions.

David didn't owe Mephibosheth anything neither did God owe us anything. If David did not owe Mephibosheth anything why would he give him a second thought? 2 Samuel 9:1 (NKJV) ***“David said, “Is there still anyone who is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan’s sake?”***

Every act of kindness and generosity from David to Mephibosheth was for Jonathan's sake! David searched Mephibosheth out with intentions of blessing, because of his relationship with Jonathan.

None of us deserve to be loved or blessed by God!

God has decided to love us and show us His kindness for Jesus' sake! Most things are better than they seem! Titus 3:5 (MESSAGE) ***“It wasn't so long ago that we ourselves were stupid and stubborn, dupes of sin, ordered every which way by our glands, going around with a chip on our shoulder, hated and hating back. But when God, our kind and loving***

Savior stepped in, he saved us from all that. It was all his doing; we had nothing to do with it. He gave us a good bath, and we came out of it new people, washed inside and out by the Holy Spirit. Our Savior Jesus poured out new life so generously. God's gift has restored our relationship with him and given us back our lives. And there's more life to come—an eternity of life! You can count on this.

III. PAST AND PRESENT CIRCUMSTANCES SHOULD NOT BE ALLOWED TO DETERMINE FUTURE SUCCESS...

As we have discovered, Mephibosheth was wasting away in his pitiful little life until King David decided to show him kindness for Jonathan's sake. Mephibosheth was brought into the King's presence. 2 Samuel 9:6 (NKJV) **"When Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, had come to David, he fell on his face and prostrated himself. Then David said, "Mephibosheth?" And he answered, "Here is your servant!"** It never occurred to Mephibosheth that the King might have summoned him for the purpose of doing him good rather than evil.

Because of years of living in hopelessness Mephibosheth assumed nothing good could befall him.

Once hope is lost, self-destructive behavior sets in. **When one begins to participate in self-**

destructive behavior: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Blessings are turned to rubbish through negligence... (One may not have the best car in the neighborhood but it should at least be kept clean)
- Opportunities are obscured by pessimistic behavior... (When personal expectations are that nothing good is going to happen, one tends to miss any opportunity for success)
- The prospect of improved conditions becomes clouded by skepticism... (When one allows his/her behavior to be clouded with sarcasm, the chances of the circumstances improving by any measureable increment is slim to none)

Thomas Jefferson said, *“I like the dreams of the future better than the history of the past.”*

Will we allow our past and present circumstances to determine our future success?

Wendy Wasserstein said, *“Don't live down to expectations. Go out there and do something remarkable.”*

Take a look at the Bible characters that allowed their promising lives to be downgraded to a lack luster existence:

- Samson... (The amazing Nazarite became a spectacle of insidious insults)

- David... (From giant killer to a passive, adulterous King who sat idly by as his own son attempted to usurp his throne)
- Judas... (From confidant of God's Son to a demon possessed suicidal maniac)
- Demas... (From disciple of the Lord Jesus Christ to a pleasure loving has been)

King David revealed his intentions to Mephibosheth! David was intent on placing Mephibosheth in a position of being blessed by the King and the Kingdom!

Father God has sent the High Sheriff of Heaven (The Holy Spirit) to CT Church to arrest (Convict) you today, not to bring you to justice but to reposition you for blessing! Will you allow past and present circumstances to dictate future success?

What is your response? You can keep living in a poverty-stricken, sin-infested, self-destructive, downward spiraling, and hopelessly depressing position if you so choose.

What is necessary to quit living in the defeat of the past and launching into the success of the future? Turn your life over to Jesus! He will wash your past away, and give you an unbelievable future! The King has Kingdom life for you today! If you will surrender your life to Him you can walk free from the restrictions of the past and step into the richness of your future successes!

IV. THOUGH DELIBERATE, THE PLAN OF GOD IS BRILLIANT...

God did not come up with a plan for Mephibosheth on the day David summoned him to the palace. The plan of God was at work in the life of Mephibosheth:

- Before he was born into the family line of Saul...
- Before his father and David became best friends...
- Before his father and grandfather were killed...
- Before he was orphaned and placed in the house of Machir...
- Before his fortunes turned from promising to pathetic...
- Before he knew who Ziba, the servant of David was...
- Before he was summoned to the palace...
- Before he met the King...
- Before his fortunes were restored...
- Before he was invited to eat at the Kings table...

The story of Mephibosheth reiterates to us the following principles: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- God is never without a plan for us...
- God does not rush to reveal His plan to us...
- God is capable of working His plan despite our present circumstances...

Think of this:

- God made Abraham the father to nations even though he was an impatient liar...
- God called Moses to be a deliverer even though he was a murderer...
- God anointed David to be King of Israel even though his resume' was a bit thin...
- God called Paul to be an Apostle even though his past actions had proven him to be an angry, self-absorbed, murdering maniac...

God has a brilliant, slow developing plan for each of us despite the baggage of the past.

The reason the plan of God is so slow to develop is:

- God is helping us unpack our past baggage so we do not use it to mess up His brilliant plan for our future...
- God is behind the scenes arranging hundreds of details so that they will all converge in the right place, at exactly the right time, for the right purpose...
- God is determined to not allow His plan to come to pass prematurely in order to keep us from messing up a set up...

While Mephibosheth was languishing in the house of Machir in Lo Debar:

- God was placing sticky notes in the mind of David concerning his relationship with Jonathan...

- God was texting Ziba thoughts of the plight of the lame son of Jonathan...
- God was e-mailing Ziba the google earth position of the only known survivor of the house of Jonathan...
- God was positioning Ziba to be the trusted servant of David...
- God was influencing the heart of Machir to be willing to share his resources with Mephibosheth until God was ready to relocate him to the palace...

Though deliberate, the plan of God was brilliant in the life of Mephibosheth! This plan included: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rescue from living in a poverty stricken desert place...
- Being brought into the presence of the King of the land...
- The kindness of the King and Kingdom being demonstrated in his life...
- Restoration of all the wealth of his father and grandfather...
- Assigning Ziba, his 15 sons and twenty servants to become custodians of all the property that had been returned to Mephibosheth...
- Eating every meal at the Kings table...
Living in the palace, never to return to the house of Machir in Lo Debar...

CONCLUSION:

Though deliberate, the plan of God for us is brilliant! His plan for us includes: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rescuing us from the poverty stricken desert of sin...
- Being repositioned for a fruitful future rather than wallowing in the pain of past experiences...
- Being made partakers of His divine nature...
- Restoration of the years that have been stolen by sinful living...
- Becoming connected to people who can assist us in achieving our life purpose...
- Dining continually at the table of the King...
- Changing our residence from sin to salvation...

I want to conclude my thoughts here with a quote from Meister Eckhart - *“For however devoted you are to God, you may be sure that he is immeasurably more devoted to you.”*

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)